Angles of Vision

By Roseann Lloyd

Tim O'Brien, author of The Things They Carried, perhaps explains it best: "In any war story, but especially a true one, it's difficult to separate what happened from what seemed to happen... The angles of vision are skewed. When a booby trap explodes, you close your eyes and duck and float outside yourself . . . The pictures get fumbled . . . you tend to miss a lot. And then afterward, when you go to tell about it, there is always that surreal seemingness, which makes the story seem untrue, but which in fact represents the hard and exact truth as it seemed."

INTRODUCTION

In this poem, Roseann Lloyd, addresses a very hidden and personal war, one waged internally against emotions. Emotions brought about by her brother's suicide, her father's abuse and her struggle to cope with life's trial and tribulations. Despite the heart-breaking subject matter, Ms. Lloyd's work as a poet has always been in honor of

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community, healing, beauty, and laughter. Her poems about incest have helped to heal a community of men and women whose fates delivered them into the wrong hands.... We all see the world through different Angles of Vision by Roseann Lloyd.

when I'm walking it's

the movement that counts

thinking whatever

flits across my mind

the way a cat tracks

each purple shadow

catching the grass

& when I'm walking I let myself

think about the doctors

who thought my symptoms indicated a tumor

buried deep

inside my head the headaches the tunnels of dazzling light

the weeping

breasts their hands wrapped my chest and legs in a blanket

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of lead a grasshopper's thorax I was held down like
when my father
was on top of me & my mind couldn't skip around
they turned my head
by the chin
like a lover positioning it so they could see
what was wrong with their pinpoints
of invisible light
& when I'm walking
I can see those x-rays they showed me mainly what you
see is skull
a chalky shadow something you think you don't get
until you're dead & bone clean dead & buried
like my brother
who got buried
the year before his hair was thick & curly
I never saw his skull I felt dead then
I couldn't think
about death couldn't say the word *incest*
which was buried
with all my feelings

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held down by my
thorax
of symptoms headaches blinded vision weeping
breast milk no connection to anything
not even my moon my husband's body
heavy & remote
& he strange as my father my brother's gaunt hip-bones
graceful as a girl walking through
my mind all the days I couldn't get up
off the couch
& when I'm walking I can see the gone days those days
on the couch we lived in the mountains
then my husband's sunlit body didn't want any part of
maniacal fathers
dying brothers not any part of the truth I could only see
in the screen of nightmares glimpses
in the morning
light it was then
I started walking
walking the muddy
back roads across

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the floodplain & up through the fat thistles of the
purple knapweed & up
even farther to the canyon walking up to the
cedars & pines
up to the cold
streams & with each step the headaches
receded memories came rushing in
like the cold water like the spring
floods swelling
the valley floor
& when I'm walking I let myself remember her that
young woman with downcast eyes
covered by the long blond hair-the woman
I used to be & I
welcome the remembering how I made her
say the words out loud in plain English without the
benefit of metaphor: *my Father sexually assaulted my body*
my Father beat
down his sons

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my youngest brother refused to fight in Asia but he
died from the Asian flowers blooming in his veins-
that's no metaphor that is the flower of addiction
what we thought was beauty was really pain:
don't tell the secrets
death rhymes with incest they're the family twins!
my father is a Gemini-
do you see how fast
I'm walking life back
into my scared stiff body that always did what it was
told & when I'm walking I can
even think about
all the dead weight
that kept me down
the thorax of
symptoms the doctors' bewilderment the rules
& threats in the name of love black-outs numb hands
nightmares hands & fists & silence & fear
of all of the above
& I'm not afraid any more when I'm walking
I forgive the men the violence their bodies

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have expended on mine all their rage & grief-

I let them have

their lives & when I'm walking I let myself have mine I

let myself think

of my friends & my lover the men unafraid to look me in

the face unafraid

to see the damage

my brothers

I have to keep moving

& there's no more headaches even in the city I'm

walking up the canyon walking with my brother's lovely

hips up through

the knapweed up to

the purple lupine the fringed gentian the scarlet gilia

& on up to the shooting stars walking into my life walking

up the canyon I never

reach the end of

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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